Indian women in 2020 and a 65 per cent boost in sex toy sales post the Covid-19 lockdown. India also remains the third-largest consumer of porn globally.

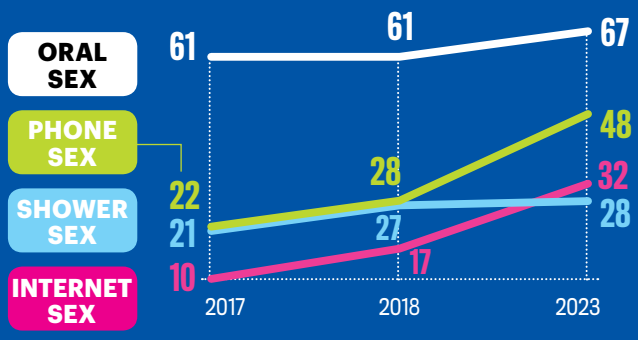
What these figures underline is that the general attitudes around sex have evolved. With total dating apps users in India expected to touch 28.4 million by 2027 (per Statista, a market insights platform), the contours of the Indian relationship culture are shifting. The INDIA TODAY sex survey shows that the number of people having phone sex and internet sex has more than doubled in the past five years: while only 22 per cent had tried phone sex in 2017, that figure stands at 48 per cent today. For internet sex, the number has gone up from 10 per cent in 2017 to 32 per cent in 2023. There is also greater acceptance towards having multiple partners and engaging

POST-COVID-19, A SLEW OF NEW FEATURES HAVE SPRUNG UP IN THE VIRTUAL DATING WORLD

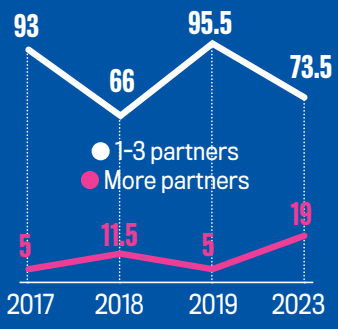
in one-night stands. In 2017, only 5 per cent of respondents had reported having had more than three sexual partners; today, 19 per cent say they've had multiple partners, whereas 54 per cent say they are open to having one-night stands, compared to 35 per cent in 2017. Ravi Mittal, CEO and founder of homegrown dating app QuackQuack, attributes these numbers to an intrinsic shift. "Yes, there is a portion of people who are interested in casual relationships, but that's always been there. It has come to light now more so because people are unapologetically comfortable with and vocal about their choices."

What can this openness be attributed to? Perhaps, the myriad options that have sprung up after the Covid-19 pandemic. There's something for everyone—while Tinder offers Hot Takes, a timed quiz to see whether two people have similar interests, Aisle has launched Jalebi, a dating app for Gen Z with audio prompts and selfie verifications, and Bumble allows videos on profiles. Video chat rooms, text chat rooms, audio chat rooms, blind date rooms—the dating app world is flush with ways to build user confidence and make sexual or romantic relationships

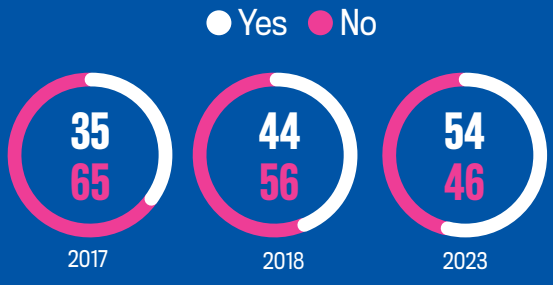
WHAT KIND/S OF EXPERIMENTS HAVE YOU HAD WITH SEX?



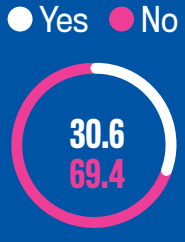
HOW MANY SEXUAL PARTNERS HAVE YOU HAD?



ARE YOU OKAY WITH ONE-NIGHT STANDS?



HAVE YOU EVER MET ANY OF YOUR VIRTUAL SEX PARTNERS IN PERSON?



58%

Share of respondents who said they might feel bad if a virtual sex partner ghosted them (vanished without an explanation or goodbye)

43%

Share of respondents who said virtual sex may lead to a long-term relationship as well